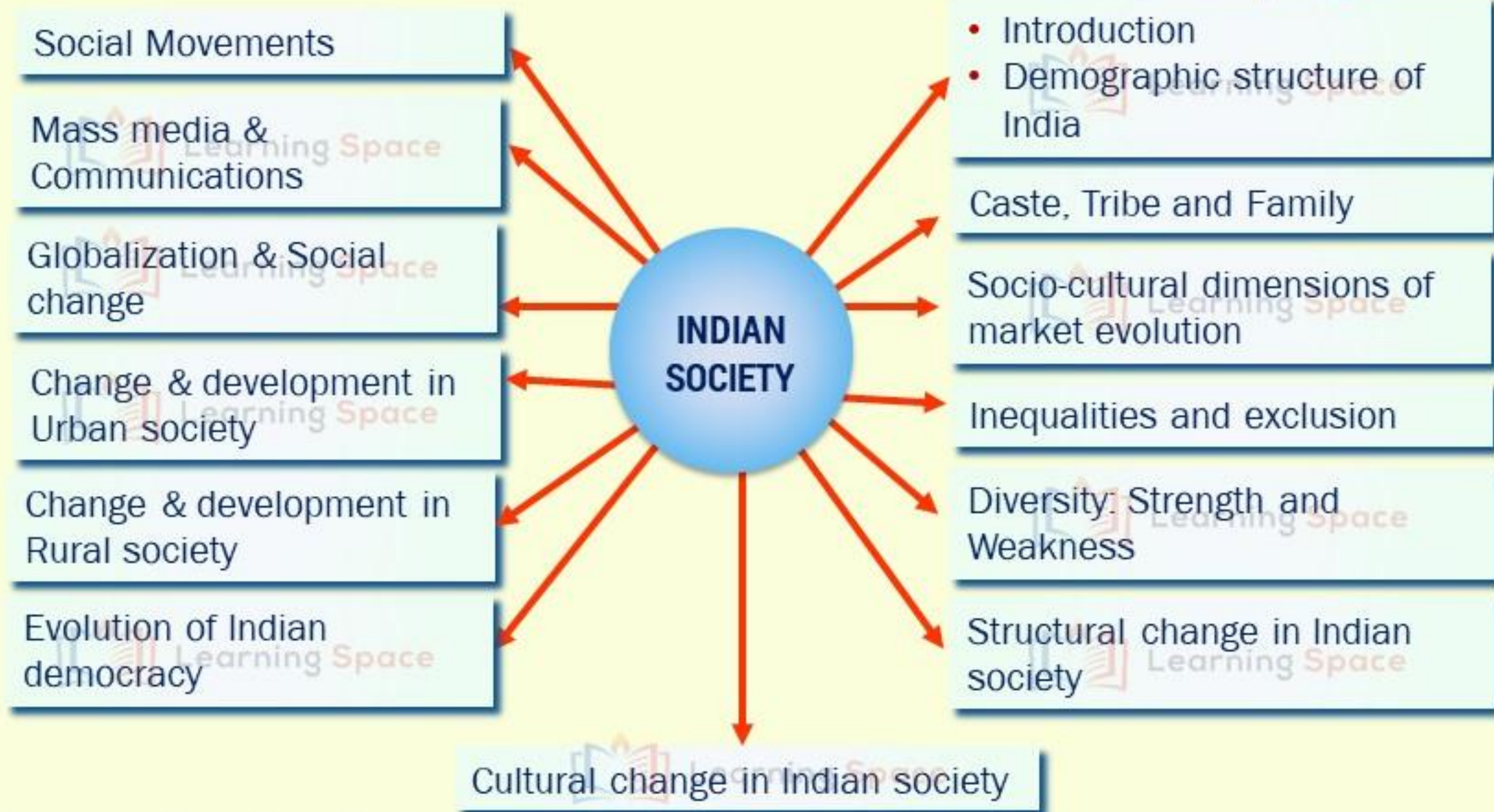




INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 2

CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!-1



2019**INDIAN SOCIETY**

- 1** What makes the Indian society unique in sustaining its culture? Discuss.
(Answer in 150 words) 10
- 2** “Empowering women is the key to control population growth.” Discuss.
(Answer in 150 words) 10
- 3** What are the challenges to our cultural practices in the name of secularism?
(Answer in 150 words) 10
- 4** Do we have cultural pockets of small India all over the nation? Elaborate with examples. (Answer in 250 words) 15
- 5** What are the continued challenges for women in India against time and space?
(Answer in 250 words) 15
- 6** Are we losing our local identity for the global identity? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words) 15

UPSC MAINS EXAMINATIONS

INDIAN SOCIETY



INTRODUCTION

- 1** Population is not just a collection of separate, unrelated individuals, it is a society made up of distinct but interlinked classes and communities of various kinds.
- 2** These communities are sustained and regulated by social institutions and social relationships.
- 3** Social institutions that are central to Indian society, are caste, tribe and family.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

Caste is an institution uniquely associated with the Indian sub-continent.

1 English word 'caste' is a borrowing from the Portuguese 'casta', meaning **pure breed**.

2 In Indian languages it is referred to by two distinct terms, **varna** and **jati**.

3 Varna, literally 'colour', is the name given to a four-fold division of society into

- ✓ brahmana
- ✓ kshatriya
- ✓ vaishya and
- ✓ shudra

4 Varna excludes a significant section of the population composed of the 'outcastes', foreigners, slaves, conquered peoples and others, often referred to as the panchamas or fifth category.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

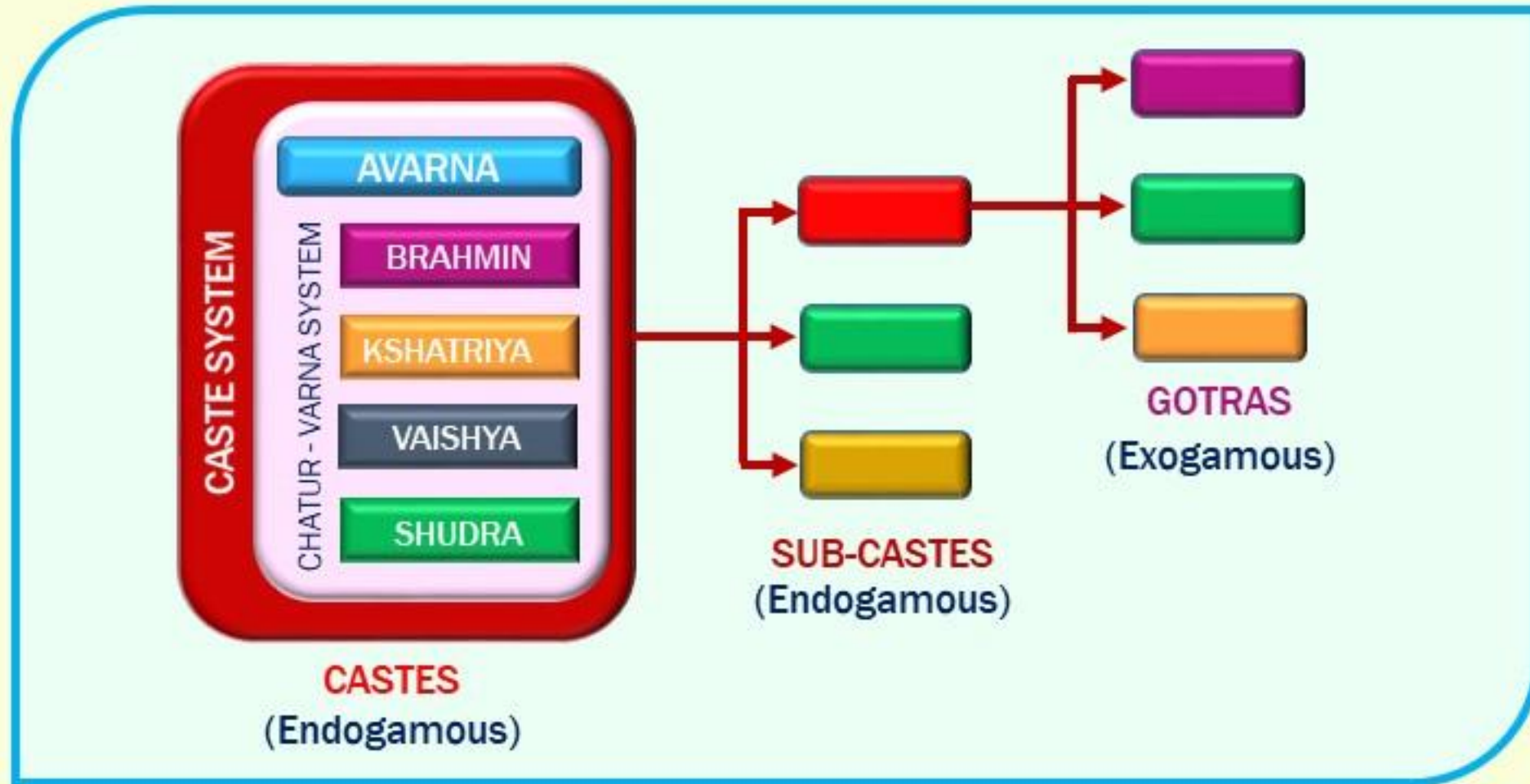
VARNA-JATI

- 1** While the four varna classification is common to all of India, the jati hierarchy has more local classifications that vary from region to region.
- 2** In its earliest phase, in the late Vedic period roughly between 900 - 500 BC, the caste system was really a varna system and consisted of only four major divisions.
- 3** These divisions were not very elaborate or very rigid, and they were not determined by birth.
- 4** Movement across the categories seems to have been not only possible but quite common.
- 5** It is only in the post- Vedic period that caste became the rigid institution that is familiar to us from well known definitions.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

VARNA- JATI



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

DEFINING FEATURES OF CASTE

- 1 Caste is determined by birth.
- 2 Segmental division: sub-divisions within themselves – Closed mutually exclusive segments.
- 3 Hierarchical division: every person has a caste, and every caste has a specified place in the hierarchy of all castes.
- 4 Restrictions on feeding and social interactions governed by ideas of purity and pollution.



G.S. GHURYE
PROFESSOR OF SOCIOLOGY

CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

DEFINING FEATURES OF CASTE

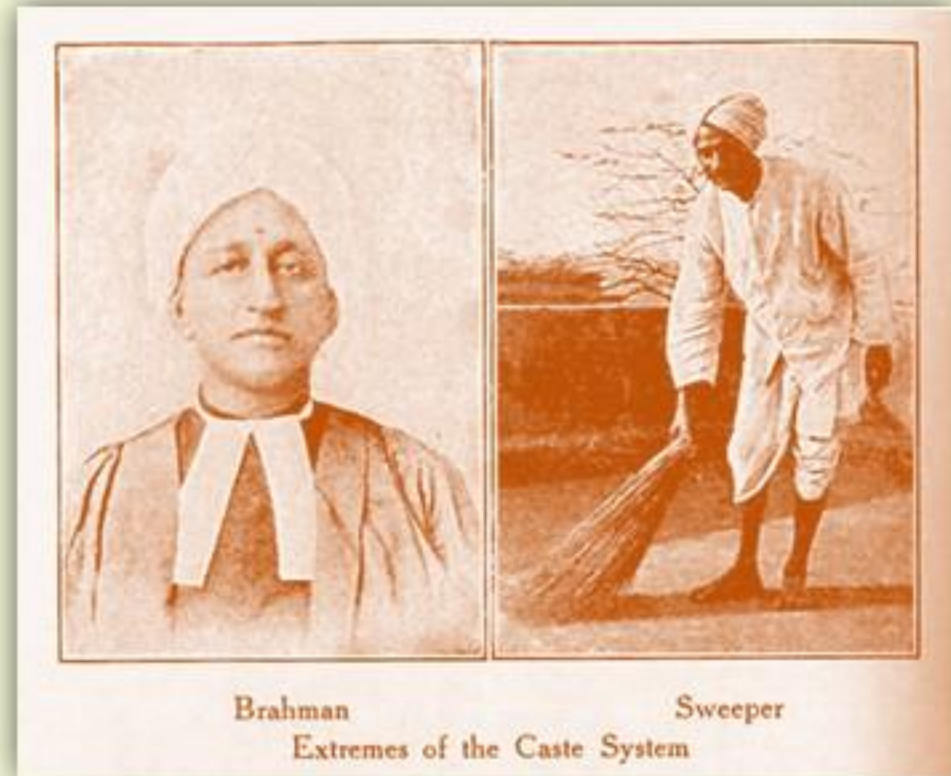
- 5** Differential rights and duties for different castes and civil and religious disabilities and privileges.
- 6** Restricts choice of occupation. Since caste is also linked with occupation, the system functions as the social division of labour, except that, in principle, it allows no mobility.
- 7** Caste groups are “endogamous”, i.e. marriage is restricted to members of the group.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

PURITY AND POLLUTION

- 1** Division between something believed to be closer to the sacred (thus connoting ritual purity), and something believed to be distant from or opposed to the sacred, therefore considered ritually polluting.
- 2** Castes that are considered ritually pure have high status, while those considered less pure or impure have low status.
- 3** As in all societies, material power (i.e., economic or military power) is closely associated with social status, so that those in power tend to be of high status, and vice versa.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

CASTE - COMBINATION OF DIFFERENCE AND SEPARATION, WHOLISM AND HIERARCHY

DIFFERENCE AND SEPARATION

- Each caste is supposed to be different from and is therefore strictly separated from every other caste.
- Many of the scriptural rules of caste are designed to prevent the mixing of castes rules ranging from marriage, food sharing and social interaction to occupation.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

CASTE - COMBINATION OF DIFFERENCE AND SEPARATION, WHOLISM AND HIERARCHY

WHOLISM

- These different and separated castes do not have an individual existence.
- They can only exist in relation to a larger whole.
- The totality of society consisting of all castes.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

CASTE - COMBINATION OF DIFFERENCE AND SEPARATION, WHOLISM AND HIERARCHY

HIERARCHY

- This societal whole or system is a hierarchical rather than egalitarian system.
- Each individual caste occupies not just a distinct place, but also an ordered rank, a particular position in a ladder-like arrangement going from highest to lowest. Hierarchical ordering of castes is based on the distinction between 'purity' and 'pollution'.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

COLONIALISM AND CASTE

- 1 British administrators tried to understand the complexities of caste in an effort to learn how to govern the country efficiently by conducting intense surveys.
- 2 1901 Census under the direction of Herbert Risley sought to collect information on the social hierarchy of caste – i.e., the social order of precedence in particular regions, as to the position of each caste in the rank order.
- 3 This kind of direct attempt to count caste and to officially record caste status changed the institution itself.



CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

COLONIALISM AND CASTE

4 Had a huge impact on social perceptions of caste and hundreds of petitions were addressed to the Census Commissioner by representatives of different castes.

5 They claimed a higher position in the social scale and offering historical and scriptural evidence for their claims.

6 Land revenue settlements and related arrangements and laws served to give legal recognition to the customary (caste-based) rights of the upper castes. These castes now became land owners in the modern sense.



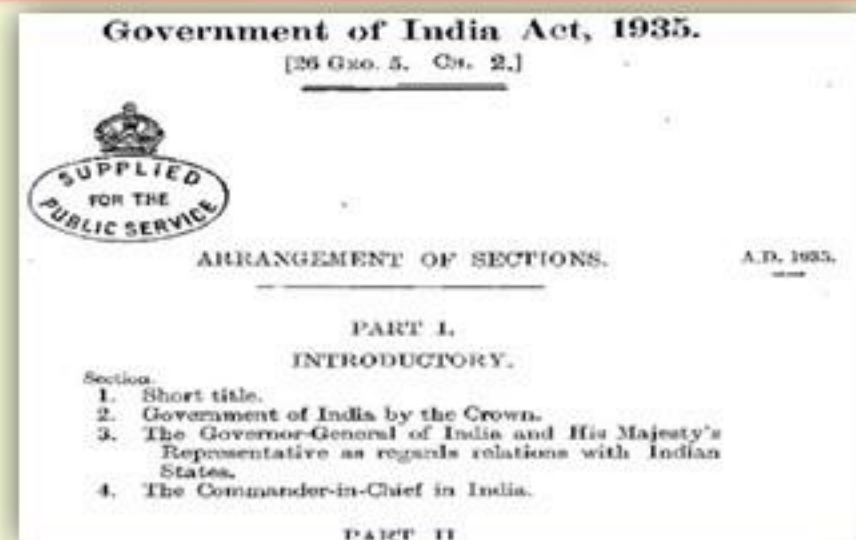
CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM!

COLONIALISM AND CASTE

7 Towards the end of the colonial period, the administration also took an interest in the welfare of downtrodden castes, referred to as the 'depressed classes' at that time.

8 Government of India Act of 1935 gave legal recognition to the lists or 'schedules' of castes and tribes marked out for special treatment by the state. This is how the terms 'Scheduled Tribes' and the 'Scheduled Castes' came into being.

9 Castes at the bottom of the hierarchy that suffered severe discrimination, including all the so-called 'untouchable' castes, were included among the Scheduled Castes.



Thus the institution of caste underwent fundamental changes during the colonial period

WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588